

Official node-ipc Post-Incident Report

Technical Analysis of the May 14, 2026 Supply-Chain Compromise

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Publication Record

This First Edition is the fixed publication of the Common DevOps investigation into the May 2026 node-ipc software supply-chain compromise. It is intended for archival distribution, persistent citation, and scholarly or professional reference.

Scope

The report documents the malicious npm releases, payload behavior, maintainer-identity attack path, domain and mailbox evidence, root cause, indicators, remediation, and lessons learned. Selected primary evidence is reproduced in the report, while the complete investigation archive is retained separately.

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Version policy

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Executive Summary

In May 2026, three malicious node-ipc releases - 9.1.6, 9.2.3, and 12.0.1 - were published through npm while the upstream project still showed version 12.0.0. The malicious packages were distributed through the official package channel and carried a compromised CommonJS bundle.

The investigation established a maintainer-identity attack path centered on the dormant atlantis-software.net domain associated with the npm publisher identity. The domain had lapsed, was re-registered, the associated mailbox was re-established and operational, and valid npm publishing authority tied to that identity was abused to release malicious package versions.

The payload performed host reconnaissance and credential discovery, staged collected material, compressed it, and implemented DNS query-name exfiltration using infrastructure associated with azurestaticprovider.net. The malicious code was appended to node-ipc.cjs, while the ESM entry point node-ipc.js remained clean.

The incident was detected publicly on 2026-05-14 through GitHub issue #15 and contained rapidly. Common DevOps subsequently preserved domain, DNS, profile, mailbox, message-authentication, and registrar evidence and compiled a structured investigation record.

Primary conclusion

A dormant maintainer identity, coupled to lapsed identity infrastructure, was exploited to abuse valid npm publishing authority and distribute malicious node-ipc artifacts through the trusted package channel.

Key facts

Field	Finding
Package	node-ipc
Upstream version	12.0.0
Malicious versions	9.1.6, 9.2.3, 12.0.1
Incident date	2026-05-14
Contained by	2026-05-15
Public detection	GitHub issue RIAEvangelist/node-ipc#15
Root cause	Dormant maintainer identity tied to lapsed atlantis-software.net domain
12.0.1 shasum	fe5d107b9d285327af579259a32977c4f475fa26
Malicious entry point	node-ipc.cjs (CommonJS)
Clean comparison path	node-ipc.js (ESM)

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1. Background

1.1 What is node-ipc?

node-ipc is an open-source JavaScript library for inter-process communication. It enables Node.js processes to exchange messages and coordinate across multi-process applications, command-line tooling, and local services. Its adoption made the incident consequential: the package has accumulated more than two billion downloads, with monthly download volume in the millions.

1.2 The source-versus-distribution gap

The incident demonstrated that the source repository developers inspect and the package artifact they install are separate trust surfaces. On 2026-05-14 the upstream project still appeared normal and showed version 12.0.0, while npm served malicious versions 9.1.6, 9.2.3, and 12.0.1. The package name remained familiar. What changed was the chain of authority controlling what the registry delivered.

2. Incident Overview

2.1 Public incident record

GitHub issue #15 was opened on 2026-05-14 at 15:01:21Z reporting that the CommonJS bundle for node-ipc 12.0.1 contained an appended obfuscated infostealer payload after the legitimate module export boundary. Investigators subsequently confirmed 9.2.3 and 9.1.6 as affected. The malicious code existed in node-ipc.cjs; the ESM entry point and other source files remained clean.

12.0.1 npm shasum

```
fe5d107b9d285327af579259a32977c4f475fa26
```

2.2 Release sequence

The investigation record documents a rapid sequence beginning with 12.0.1 at approximately 14:25:30, followed by 9.2.3 and then 9.1.6 at roughly 30-second intervals.

2.3 Timeline

Date / time	Event
2026-05-07 11:49:33Z	Current atlantis-software.net registration created.
2026-05-14 07:26:10Z	azurestaticprovider.net registration created.
2026-05-14 ~14:25:30	First malicious publication; additional affected versions follow rapidly.
2026-05-14 15:01:21Z	GitHub security issue #15 opened.
2026-05-14	Independent confirmation and npm security notification.
2026-05-15	WHOIS, npm/GitHub profile, and DNS evidence preserved.
2026-05-15	Repository owner restricted write access.
2026-05-16 13:43	Final preserved mailbox reply captured.
2026-05-19	Preservation request sent to Namecheap.
2026-05-22	Namecheap final response and legal-process requirement.

3. Impact Assessment

3.1 Why developer environments matter

Developer workstations and CI runners sit at the intersection of source code, credentials, infrastructure, and release automation. They commonly possess access to private repositories, package registries, cloud accounts, deployment systems, Kubernetes clusters, databases, and production-adjacent services.

3.2 Trust propagation

A supply-chain payload does not need to break into every downstream system independently. It can execute inside an environment that already possesses legitimate trust and credentials. In this incident the attack path crossed maintainer identity, publishing authority, registry distribution, package execution, developer secrets, and downstream systems.

3.3 Exposure model

For defenders, exposure should be assessed as a progression: affected version resolved, compromised CommonJS path loaded, credential material read, archive staged, DNS exfiltration attempted, and credentials potentially reused. This gives responders a practical basis for host-by-host investigation and credential rotation.

Trust-chain model

Layer	Compromise effect
Maintainer identity	Controls or recovers publishing access.
Publishing authority	Produces registry releases accepted as legitimate.
Package registry	Distributes malicious artifacts through normal dependency resolution.
Developer / CI runtime	Executes the trusted dependency.
Credentials	Expose tokens, keys, cloud and cluster configuration.
Downstream systems	Existing credentials extend reach beyond the original package.

4. Technical Analysis

4.1 Entry point

The malicious payload was appended to `node-ipc.cjs`, the CommonJS entry point. The ESM entry point `node-ipc.js` and other source files were clean.

4.2 Reconnaissance and credential collection

The payload surveyed the host and targeted platform and architecture details, hostname, home and temporary directories, working directory, process information, environment variables, `/etc/hosts`, SSH material, shell history, cloud configuration, Kubernetes configuration, application configuration, source-control credentials, and package-management credentials.

4.3 Staging and compression

The payload constructed a tar archive, compressed it using `zlib.gzipSync()`, and staged material beneath a temporary `nt-*` path. A manifest-like `_paths.txt` file was part of the reconstructed staging logic.

4.4 DNS exfiltration

The exfiltration design encoded staged data into DNS query names. The protocol used `xh` for header messages, `xd` for data chunks, and `xf` for footer messages. The incident record identified `sh.azurestaticprovider.net` as the resolver/C2-related host and `bt.node.js` as part of the query-name structure.

4.5 Process behavior

The payload used detached child-process behavior, environment guards such as `__ntw` and `__ntRun`, and cleanup of temporary staging material.

4.6 C2 infrastructure

WHOIS evidence preserved during the investigation records `azurestaticprovider.net` as created on 2026-05-14T07:26:10Z through NICENIC INTERNATIONAL GROUP CO., LIMITED, with nameservers `NS3.MY-NDNS.COM` and `NS4.MY-NDNS.COM`. DNS responses and authoritative-name-server information were also preserved.

5. Attribution and Evidence

5.1 Maintainer identity and publishing path

The malicious package metadata identified the npm publisher identity `atierant` with the associated address `a.tierant@atlantis-software.net`. The identity was a known maintainer identity associated with `node-ipc` publishing.

5.2 Domain evidence

The investigation established that the maintainer domain had lapsed and returned under new control before the malicious publication. The preserved WHOIS capture records `ATLANTIS-SOFTWARE.NET` under Namecheap with a creation date of `2026-05-07T11:49:33Z`.

5.3 Mailbox control

A preserved six-message thread documents direct communication with `a.tierant@atlantis-software.net`. Replies were received from the re-established mailbox. Message authentication records for the final preserved reply show SPF PASS using IP `198.54.127.77` and DKIM PASS for `atlantis-software.net`.

5.4 Preservation activity

On `2026-05-19`, Common DevOps submitted a preservation request to Namecheap covering registrar-account details, login IPs and user agents, account recovery events, DNS and mail history, mailbox creation records, webmail sessions, SMTP submission logs, DKIM signing records, support/recovery events, and related abuse or fraud flags.

Evidence interpretation

The identity, domain, mailbox, package metadata, publishing sequence, and preserved communications form a coherent attack path: a dormant maintainer identity remained connected to package publishing authority after its underlying identity infrastructure had lapsed; that identity infrastructure was restored under new control; publishing authority was then abused to distribute malware.

Selected Primary Evidence

The following figures reproduce preserved artifacts from the investigation archive. They are included in the production edition to place key identity, domain, and mailbox evidence directly beside the published findings.

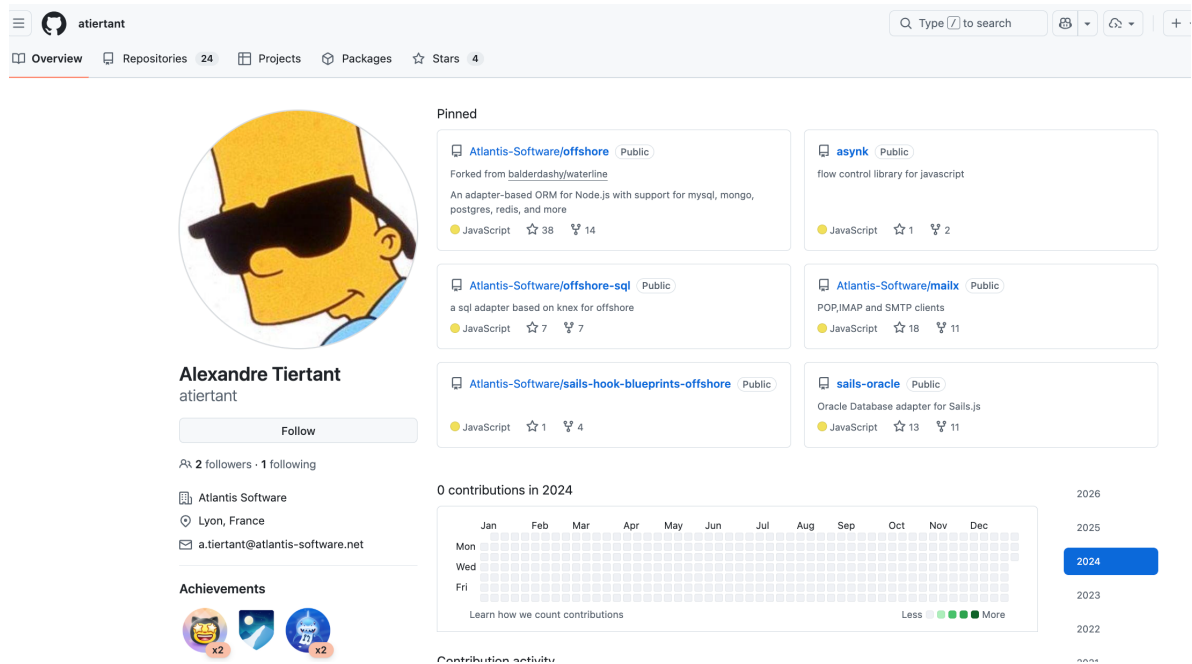


Figure 1. Contemporaneous GitHub profile associated with the atiertant maintainer identity.

```
# whois.namecheap.com

Domain name: atlantis-software.net
Registry Domain ID: 3096499355_DOMAIN_NET-VRSN
Registrar WHOIS Server: whois.namecheap.com
Registrar URL: http://www.namecheap.com
Updated Date: 0001-01-01T00:00:00.00Z
Creation Date: 2026-05-07T11:49:33.00Z
Registrar Registration Expiration Date: 2027-05-07T11:49:33.00Z
Registrar: NAMECHEAP INC
Registrar IANA ID: 1068
Registrar Abuse Contact Email: abuse@namecheap.com
Registrar Abuse Contact Phone: +1.9854014545
Reseller: NAMECHEAP INC
Domain Status: clientTransferProhibited https://icann.org/epp#clientTransferProhibited
Domain Status: addPeriod https://icann.org/epp#addPeriod
Registry Registrant ID:
Registrant Name: Redacted for Privacy
Registrant Organization: Privacy service provided by Withheld for Privacy ehf
Registrant Street: Kalkofnsvegur 2
Registrant City: Reykjavik
Registrant State/Province: Capital Region
Registrant Postal Code: 101
Registrant Country: IS
Registrant Phone: +354.4212434
Registrant Phone Ext:
Registrant Fax:
Registrant Fax Ext:
Registrant Email: aa0e0a5ff4de445787e143af0ec7c520.protect@withheldforprivacy.com
Registry Admin ID:
Admin Name: Redacted for Privacy
Admin Organization: Privacy service provided by Withheld for Privacy ehf
Admin Street: Kalkofnsvegur 2
Admin City: Reykjavik
Admin State/Province: Capital Region
Admin Postal Code: 101
Admin Country: IS
Admin Phone: +354.4212434
Admin Phone Ext:
Admin Fax:
Admin Fax Ext:
Admin Email: aa0e0a5ff4de445787e143af0ec7c520.protect@withheldforprivacy.com
Registry Tech ID:
Tech Name: Redacted for Privacy
Tech Organization: Privacy service provided by Withheld for Privacy ehf
Tech Street: Kalkofnsvegur 2
```

Figure 2. WHOIS capture for atlantis-software.net preserved during the investigation.

```
# whois.nicenic.com

Domain Name: azurestaticprovider.net
Registry Domain ID: D202605142086685-COM
Registrar WHOIS Server: whois.nicenic.com
Registrar URL: https://nicenic.com
Updated Date: 2026-05-14T07:26:10Z
Creation Date: 2026-05-14T07:26:10Z
Registrar Registration Expiration Date: 2027-05-14T07:26:10Z
Registrar: NICENIC INTERNATIONAL GROUP CO., LIMITED
Registrar IANA ID: 3765
Registrar Abuse Contact Email: abuse@nicenic.net
Reseller:
Domain Status: clientDeleteProhibited https://icann.org/epp#clientDeleteProhibited
Domain Status: clientTransferProhibited https://icann.org/epp#clientTransferProhibited
Registry Registrant ID: REDACTED FOR PRIVACY
Registrant Organization:
Registrant State/Province: Hong Kong
Registrant Country: HK
Registrant Email: http://whois.nicenic.com/?page=whoisform
Admin Email: http://whois.nicenic.com/?page=whoisform&emailtype=admin
Tech Email: http://whois.nicenic.com/?page=whoisform&emailtype=tech
Name Server: NS3.MY-NDNS.COM
Name Server: NS4.MY-NDNS.COM
DNSSEC: unsigned
URL of the ICANN WHOIS Data Problem Reporting System: http://wdprs.internic.net/
>>> Last update of WHOIS database: 2026-05-14T07:26:10Z <<<
```

Figure 3. WHOIS capture for azurestaticprovider.net, the domain family associated with the DNS exfiltration infrastructure.

Node-IPC breach

6 messages

Brandon Nozaki Miller <brandon@diginow.it>
To: a.tiertant@atlantis-software.net

Fri, May 15, 2026 at 1:32 AM

Hey whats up?

a.tiertant@atlantis-software.net <a.tiertant@atlantis-software.net>
To: Brandon Nozaki Miller <brandon@diginow.it>

Sat, May 16, 2026 at 2:01 AM

meow

On 05/15/2026 1:32 AM CDT Brandon Nozaki Miller <brandon@diginow.it> wrote:

Hey whats up?

Brandon Nozaki Miller <brandon@diginow.it>
To: "a.tiertant@atlantis-software.net" <a.tiertant@atlantis-software.net>

Sat, May 16, 2026 at 10:41 AM

Mrow? Meow meow, mrrrp?

Translation: "How are you?"



Figure 4. Preserved six-message mailbox exchange involving a.tiertant@atlantis-software.net.

Original Message

Message ID	<1535103746.754187.1778957015937@privateemail.com>
Created at:	Sat, May 16, 2026 at 1:43 PM (Delivered after 5 seconds)
From:	"a.tiertant@atlantis-software.net a.tiertant@atlantis-software.net" <a.tiertant@atlantis-software.net> Using Open-Xchange Mailer v7.10.6-Rev91
To:	Brandon Nozaki Miller <brandon@diginow.it>
Subject:	Re: Node-IPC breach
SPF:	PASS with IP 198.54.127.77 Learn more
DKIM:	'PASS' with domain atlantis-software.net Learn more
DMARC:	'FAIL' Learn more

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```
Delivered-To: brandon@diginow.it
Received: by 2002:a05:7300:8189:b0:2ea:d0a7:908c with SMTP id
m9csp996533dye; Sat, 16 May 2026 11:43:40 -0700 (PDT)
X-Received: by 2002:a0c:f109:0:b0:8ac:801d:c3dc with SMTP id
6a1803df08f44-8ca0f5c456amr123783256d6.9.1778957020264; Sat, 16 May
2026 11:43:40 -0700 (PDT)
ARC-Seal: i=1; a=rsa-sha256; t=1778957020; cv=none; d=google.com;
s=arc-20240605;
b=cqThqhpNec8sEkN7wB1+1fNwC941/PWg2ds5Utr34Fbd2Bg9DE3NtoTjaGCFTzmVE
z8r1/jI6UDPKtuMGYXSZB/JqGpiGm19WD2oobXN7dQuFb1w2wDUCb1qAwc7WZF9aSONL
mT++pZeQRme1NgNBc2oUOpX6NVd4ko8DVE00xFCdU41jQcjcmaHbhc0IOWGMr7VtDUUx
PESf6vCN/DDgEHeYqW4w5A7PS+nHwc05noHcaCbt1Fq706qJwfdJ2Wf4IJEYted+hR
ljf/nIcoUd/sQk6pbZSu4VufffgfYwQSVBfgf587x09+vZGyooZTp6Qg2J414tjHY+28
qQXw==
ARC-Message-Signature: i=1; a=rsa-sha256; c=relaxed/relaxed;
d=google.com; s=arc-20240605; h=importance:mime-
version:subject:references:in-reply-to:message-id
:to:from:date:dkim-signature;
bh=qaeFgq9+ZTdTUUueM3IgJg3bnzyDMCOW2ztR3At8ieo=;
```

Figure 5. Original-message export for the final preserved reply, showing SPF PASS and DKIM PASS for atlantis-software.net.

6. Root Cause Analysis

6.1 Dormant identity infrastructure

The root failure was not a defect in the upstream source repository. It was a failure in the identity and publishing trust chain. A maintainer identity retained meaningful publishing authority while relying on an email domain that was no longer continuously controlled by the original maintainer.

6.2 Root-cause statement

The node-ipc compromise was enabled by dormant maintainer publishing authority tied to lapsed identity infrastructure. Re-registration and restoration of the maintainer email domain provided control of an identity path associated with the publisher account, and valid npm publishing authority was abused to distribute malicious package artifacts.

Classification

This incident should be classified as both a software supply-chain compromise and an identity lifecycle failure.

7. Detection and Indicators

7.1 Package indicators

Affected versions: 9.1.6, 9.2.3, 12.0.1. Compromised path: node-ipc.cjs. Clean comparison path: node-ipc.js. 12.0.1 shasum: fe5d107b9d285327af579259a32977c4f475fa26.

7.2 Runtime indicators

Key runtime indicators include __ntw=1, __ntRun, temporary nt-* staging directories, access to credential-bearing developer files, and detached Node.js child-process behavior.

7.3 Network indicators

Network indicators include sh.azurestaticprovider.net, azurestaticprovider.net, bt.node.js, DNS prefixes xh/xd/xf, unusually long or high-entropy DNS labels, and Node.js DNS traffic outside approved resolvers.

8. Remediation and Recommendations

8.1 Immediate

Remove stale publisher identities; hunt developer systems and CI environments for affected versions; rotate credentials on systems that executed affected CommonJS versions; block and investigate DNS indicators; preserve DNS, endpoint, process, and identity telemetry.

8.2 Near term

Require phishing-resistant MFA where available; review recovery channels independently from login MFA; monitor maintainer-domain expiration or ownership changes; reduce long-lived developer secrets; restrict DNS egress; compare published package contents against expected source/build artifacts.

8.3 Strategic

Treat package-publishing access like production access. Establish publisher lifecycle governance, provenance verification for critical packages, rapid takedown procedures, and exercises that treat dependency compromise as both a software and identity incident.

8.4 Trust-path analysis

A dependency incident should trigger a broader investigation than 'Which version did we install?' Teams should determine what code path executed, what credentials were reachable, what downstream systems those credentials opened, and what trust assumptions allowed the package to execute.

9. Lessons Learned

9.1 Existing trust is the attack surface

The attack did not need a new package name or an unfamiliar installation path. It benefited from trust that node-ipc had already earned.

9.2 Trust belongs to the chain

Trust belongs to maintainers, identities, recovery channels, registries, publishing controls, build systems, artifacts, dependency resolvers, and runtime environments - not to a package name alone.

9.3 Dormant access is security debt

An inactive maintainer account, expired domain, forgotten recovery address, or stale publisher role can remain security-relevant long after its operational purpose ends.

9.4 Conclusion

The May 2026 node-ipc incident demonstrates how identity compromise and software distribution converge. A maintainer identity connected to lapsed infrastructure remained part of the package-publishing trust path. That path was exploited, valid publishing authority was abused, malicious artifacts entered the official npm channel, and the resulting payload targeted the credentials and configuration that make developer and CI environments strategically valuable.

Appendix A - Evidence Register

The investigation preserved a structured evidence set. The hashes below support integrity checking of the archived artifacts.

ID	Artifact	Role	SHA-256 / locator
E-01	GitHub issue RIAEvangelist/node-ipc#251 and public incident record	Primary problem	URL-based source
E-02	NODE-IPC.pdf	Compiled investigation screenshots	5947a56cf21ebfe84a2f058363cc7fa6437ca7bfab84ea51eed862546a62fadc
E-03	Attachments.zip	Original screenshot archive	3ffb9b66c8cbffc1a763d8930bca775050f3596591cdcd3057861525aab39e5
E-04	digiNow.Mail-.Node-IPC.breach.pdf	Preserved mailbox exchange	02a4d49183f2e8b8de9b1dde20918af38fc0c011174cba103877c83e875e27b1
E-05	Original.Message.3.pdf	Original message/header export	30fd5dc7683ff00fb3c363b109a1f0fc1fd2ebe45ff1f9b5131f457cba164768
E-06	Urgent preservation requesteml	Initial Namecheap preservation request	682dc8dd1501188e35af3fa5fd1de1157cd6c3cfd30d208d39f4ba95671bfe9
E-07	[NC-HHL-2847] ... (1).eml	Namecheap acknowledgement	94b4e53d04de427990e54a676412c4ffa9938ad42881b436dcf6f357ea475144
E-08	Re_ [NC-HHL-2847]eml	Investigator follow-up	64f7e0b064aabc663b0870033b791bd1bc369f4e817be4962714cd45a0da3ad2
E-09	[NC-HHL-2847]eml	Namecheap final response	add337e740d20c0080c41dc53034021fde2930e577309aed9cf7cb3645b41265

Appendix B - Research Method and Verification

B.1 Research method

The investigation combined primary public incident records with independently preserved technical and identity evidence. The workflow included package and release analysis, WHOIS and DNS capture, maintainer-profile preservation, mailbox verification, message-authentication analysis, registrar correspondence, cross-checking against independent security research, and preservation of original artifacts with cryptographic hashes.

B.2 Evidence preservation

The evidence archive includes contemporaneous screenshots, original email artifacts, full message headers, registrar correspondence, public incident records, interview material, and structured evidence records. Cryptographic hashes are recorded for preserved artifacts in Appendix A to support integrity verification.

B.3 Verification

Findings in this report were verified against the investigation record before publication. Selected artifacts are reproduced in the report for direct inspection; additional supporting material remains in the retained evidence archive.

B.4 Reproducibility

Where practical, the report identifies package versions, timestamps, domains, message-authentication results, shasums, indicators, source locations, and evidence hashes so independent reviewers can correlate published findings with preserved records and public sources.

Appendix C - Authors and Investigation Team

C.1 Authors

Aaron Schneider led the independent Common DevOps investigation into the domain, DNS, email, registrar, package, and publishing-path evidence.

Dr. Ian Miller and Javier Bonilla assisted in the investigation and production of the incident paper.

C.2 Incident investigators and contributors

The public investigation began when @nullcharb (Ahmed) opened GitHub security issue #15. The incident was first reported to npm by @carlini (Nicholas Carlini). Investigators and contributors identified in the public thread include @RIAEvangelist, @nullcharb, @carlini, @ashishkurmi, @cyb3rjerry, @Roni-Carta, @jimmytsadiotis, and @danielweck.

C.3 Common DevOps contribution

- Independent domain, DNS, email, and registrar investigation.
- Contemporaneous preservation of WHOIS, DNS, npm/GitHub profile, and mailbox evidence.
- Authentication analysis of preserved email headers.
- Preservation request submitted to Namecheap on 2026-05-19.
- Evidence register E-01 through E-09 with cryptographic hashes.
- Interview with repository owner Brandon Miller.
- Production of the structured post-incident report and archival publication edition.

References

Primary incident record

RIAEvangelist/node-ipc. GitHub Issue #15: security report and investigation thread.
<https://github.com/RIAEvangelist/node-ipc/issues/15>

Common DevOps publication

Common DevOps.
<https://commondevops.com/node-ipc-supply-chain-incident-report/>

Independent technical coverage

- Datadog Security Labs - malware and payload analysis of the node-ipc compromise.
- Socket.dev - package compromise detection and incident timeline.
- StepSecurity - software supply-chain attack analysis and trust-boundary perspective.

Standards and technical references

- SPF - Sender Policy Framework.
- DKIM - DomainKeys Identified Mail.
- DMARC - Domain-based Message Authentication, Reporting, and Conformance.
- SPDX - Software Package Data Exchange / SBOM ecosystem.